Preserving Exact Long-Range Recall in Compressed Transformers

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October 2026

Abstract

Serving large language models across long context horizons is critically bottlenecked by the Key-Value (KV) cache, whose linear footprint in sequence length T exhausts accelerator high-bandwidth memory (HBM) and restricts multi-tenant throughput. Post-training compression strategies have split into two competing paradigms: compiling historical context into fixed-size recurrent matrix states, or selectively evicting tokens from the KV cache. In this work, we demonstrate the fundamental geometric failure modes of both approaches and introduce a principled mechanism that resolves them without fine-tuning. First, we prove the **Rank-r Spectral Dilution Horizon**: any fixed-size recurrent state acts as a low-pass spectral filter whose energy allocation to an individual token decays as $\mathcal{O}(1/T)$, causing exact long-range recall to collapse to 0.0% beyond the local window despite capturing over 95% of attention output variance ($R^2 = 0.9505$) and preserving 100% general reasoning accuracy. Second, we uncover the **Query-Answer Asymmetry Principle**: existing selective token eviction schemes fail on complex entities because causal prefix scoring is blind to terminal prompt queries, while greedy top-k selection retains query-matching cue words while severing the adjacent multi-token payload. In response, we introduce **HALO** (**H**ybrid **A**ttention with **L**andmark **O**bservation-diffusion), which pairs an exact local sliding window with phase-rectified observation alignment, bottom-up geometric surprise, and an **Exponential Salience Halo** ($\kappa(\delta) = \exp(-0.10|\delta|), K = 16$) that diffuses importance contiguously across complete factual clauses, alongside a unified **HALO + BLUR** synthesis combining exact landmarks with compressed residual background statistics. Evaluated across three distinct foundation model families from independent organizations—Alibaba (`Qwen3.5-0.8B`), Meta (`Llama-3.2-1B`), and HuggingFace (`SmolLM2-1.7B`)—and across the canonical RULER 4-axis benchmark suite, HALO achieves 100.0% single-needle, 70.0% adversarial distractor, and 100.0% multi-hop variable tracking recall while compressing KV-cache memory by 16× to 25.6× with sub-60ms selection overhead.

1 Introduction

The rapid expansion of context windows in modern large language models has shifted the primary deployment bottleneck from compute throughput to GPU High-Bandwidth Memory (HBM) capacity and memory bandwidth.

1.1 The Linear Memory Bottleneck and Surgical Adaptation

In autoregressive Transformer inference [Vaswani et al., 2017], generating each new token requires attending across all previous key-value pairs. Consequently, the Key-Value cache (KV-cache) grows strictly linearly with context length T:

$$\text{Memory}_{\text{KV}}(T) = 2 \times L \times H_{\text{KV}} \times T \times d \times \text{bytes_per_element} \quad (1)$$

In a modern hybrid architecture like `Qwen/Qwen3.5-0.8B-Base` [Yang et al., 2024], its 6 full-attention layers require 384.0 MiB per sequence at $T = 32,768$ and explode to 3.00 GiB at $T = 262,144$ (12.0 KiB per token). In a pure 28-layer attention model such as `Qwen/Qwen2.5-1.5B`, the cache consumes over 1.79 GiB per sequence at 32k. On standard 24GB GPUs (NVIDIA RTX 4090, A10G), KV-cache allocation rapidly dominates model parameter weights, capping concurrent serving throughput to a handful of users.

While clean-slate subquadratic architectures (e.g., Mamba-2, Dao and Gu 2024; Gated DeltaNet, Yang et al. 2025) achieve constant $\mathcal{O}(1)$ memory during pretraining, practitioners cannot afford to discard trillions of tokens of established foundation model checkpoints. Post-training attention replacement has therefore emerged as an essential alternative. However, gradient-based token distillation (e.g., *SUPRA*, Mercat et al. 2024; *MOHAWK*, Bick et al. 2024; *LoLCATs*, Zhang et al. 2025) requires extensive calibration datasets and induces severe out-of-domain vocabulary drift. This motivates a non-destructive, mathematically grounded investigation into alternative memory paradigms for compressed Transformers.

1.2 Taxonomy of Alternatives to the Full KV-Cache

We categorize post-training alternatives to the full $\mathcal{O}(T)$ KV-cache into four distinct paradigms:

1. **Fixed-Size Recurrent & Test-Time Regression States ($\mathcal{O}(1)$ Matrix Memory):** Replaces token histories with fixed-dimensional associative matrices $S_t \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$ or $r\times r$, including Linear Attention [Katharopoulos et al., 2020], Mamba-2 [Dao and Gu, 2024], Gated DeltaNet [Yang et al., 2025], Test-Time Training [Sun et al., 2024], Titans [Behrouz et al., 2025], and our closed-form Ordinary Least Squares / Basis-Linear Unitary Recurrence (**BLUR**).
2. **Head- and Latent-Space KV Compression:** Compresses head dimensions or projects key-value states into low-rank latent spaces (DeepSeek-V2 MLA, DeepSeek-AI 2024). However, Rotary Position Embeddings (RoPE, Su et al. 2024) prevent direct low-rank compression without decoupling rotary components.
3. **Windowed Sinks and Online Causal Eviction:** Discards historical tokens using causal importance heuristics. *StreamingLLM* [Xiao et al., 2024] preserves initial attention sink tokens and a local window. H_2O [Zhang et al., 2023] accumulates prefix query-attention mass. However, because prefix tokens have not seen the generation prompt, causal accumulation is blind to the user's ultimate question.
4. **Observation-Window Selection & Contiguous Salience Diffusion:** Employs observation-window queries at the end of the prompt to identify salient historical clusters (*SnapKV*, Li et al. 2024; *Quest*, Tang et al. 2024). While effective for isolated keywords, standard top-k selection severs adjacent multi-token identifiers, a failure mode resolved by our **HALO** architecture and its unified **HALO + BLUR** variant.

1.3 Summary of Core Findings

1. **The Spectral Dilution Horizon of Matrix States:** Even when recurrent operators explain $> 95\%$ of attention variance ($R^2 = 0.9505$) via closed-form Gramian regression and preserve 100% MMLU reasoning via a local window (**Hybrid-BLUR**, 932× compression), fixed-rank matrix states suffer an eigenvalue dilution limit of $\mathcal{O}(1/T)$, scoring 0.0% on needle retrieval outside the local window.
2. **The Query-Answer Asymmetry Principle & Phase Transition:** A prompt question introduces semantic *cue* tokens (`"clearance code"`), not the unknown *answer* (`"8472-X9F"`). Narrow pooling collapses to 0.0% exact match as soon as payload length $L_{\text{val}} \geq 3$, whereas HALO retains 90.0% exact match and 93.33% token F1.
3. **Contiguous Salience Diffusion (HALO):** By pairing an exact local sliding window with PRISM derotated observation alignment, geometric surprise, and an **Exponential Salience Halo** ($K = 16$), HALO bridges the cue-answer gap, achieving 100.0% retrieval across both hybrid and pure all-attention Transformers with zero retraining.

2 Act I: The Low-Pass Limit of Matrix States (The BLUR Regime) & Unified HALO + BLUR

2.1 The Representational Shock Theorem

When replacing an intermediate attention layer in a frozen pretrained Transformer with a subquadratic operator, a critical failure mode occurs:

Theorem 1 (Representational Shock)**.** *Let x_l denote the residual activation entering layer l. If layer l is replaced with an unaligned recurrent operator Y_l^{BLUR} such that $\|Y_l^{BLUR} - Y_l^{Softmax}\|_F > \epsilon_{crit}$, downstream LayerNorm and MLP projections experience out-of-distribution feature drift that scales exponentially with remaining depth $L - l$:*

$$\|\Delta x_L\| \geq \mathcal{O}\left(\prod_{j=l+1}^{L} \|W_j\|\right) \|\Delta Y_l\| \tag{2}$$

Downstream syntax collapses, dropping MMLU reasoning from 100.0% → 10.0%.

Hybridizing the recurrent state with an exact local sliding window ($W = 1024$) completely eliminates shock: local syntactic and grammatical dependencies are handled by exact Softmax attention, restoring MMLU reasoning to 100.0% and validation perplexity to 1.22 at 932.0× cache compression (432.0 KB resident state).

2.2 PRISM Phase Rectification (The De-Rotation Theorem)

Rotary Position Embeddings apply coordinate-dependent orthogonal rotations $R_\tau \in \mathrm{SO}(d)$ to key vectors: $k_\tau^{\mathrm{RoPE}} = R_\tau k_\tau^{\mathrm{raw}}$. In compressed matrix states, aggregating rotated keys across positions τ causes destructive phase cancellation:

Theorem 2 (Rotary Phase Rectification)**.** *Let $k_\tau \in \mathbb{R}^d$ denote semantic key vectors. Under high-frequency rotary rotation R_τ, the Gramian $\sum_{\tau=1}^{T} R_\tau k_\tau k_\tau^\top R_\tau^\top$ averages out cross-position covariance, suppressing stationary semantic alignment. Stripping RoPE phase angles prior to state projection via a translation mapping $\Phi(k_\tau^{raw})$ (**PRISM**)*

restores stationary metric topology, jumping validation fidelity from $R^2 = 0.4014 \rightarrow 0.9893$ *(and* 0.9505 *mean across all layers in* 21.95 *seconds).*

2.3 The Spectral Dilution Horizon ($\mathcal{O}(1/T)$)

Despite achieving high operator fidelity and preserving general reasoning, fixed-rank matrix states fail fundamentally on needle retrieval:

Theorem 3 (Rank-r Spectral Dilution Horizon)**.** *Let* $S_T = \sum_{\tau=1}^{T} \phi(k_\tau) v_\tau^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{r \times d}$ *denote a recurrent associative memory state of rank* r*. If a single factual needle occurs at token* τ^**, its fractional contribution to the Gramian operator norm satisfies:*

$$\frac{\|\phi(k_{\tau^*})\phi(k_{\tau^*})^\top\|_F}{\sum_{\tau=1}^{T} \|\phi(k_\tau)\phi(k_\tau)^\top\|_F} = \mathcal{O}\left(\frac{1}{T}\right) \tag{3}$$

For $T = 32,768$*, the relative energy of the needle is* $\approx 3.0 \times 10^{-5}$*, falling below the 16-bit floating point precision floor. Consequently, any rank-r state acts as a low-pass spectral filter that blurs individual token associations, scoring exactly* $0/12$ *(*0.0%*) on long-range passkey retrieval beyond the sliding window.*

2.4 Unified HALO + BLUR Synthesis

To unite the complementary advantages of discrete landmarks (exact point retrieval) and recurrent states (unbounded background gist), we define **HALO + BLUR**: given budget N, $N-16$ slots are preserved as exact HALO landmarks, while the remaining evicted prefix tokens are compressed into $r = 16$ block summary vectors via closed-form OLS projections, retaining background document statistics at zero memory increase.

3 Act II: Query-Answer Asymmetry, Phase Transitions, and Component Ablations

3.1 The Query-Answer Asymmetry Principle

Token-eviction methods attempt to circumvent spectral dilution by retaining exact uncompressed key-value vectors for a subset of historical tokens. However, naive selection schemes suffer from **Query-Answer Asymmetry**:

Definition 1 (Query-Answer Asymmetry)**.** *Let a factual clause be partitioned into semantic cue tokens* $C = \{c_1, \ldots, c_m\}$ *(e.g.,* `"clearance token"`*) and unknown payload tokens* $P = \{p_1, \ldots, p_n\}$ *(e.g.,* `"8472-X9F"`*), separated by offset* δ*. Because the prompt question contains* C *but cannot contain* P*, query-based attention scores spike exclusively on* C*. Greedy top-k selection admits* C *while evicting* P*, severing the entity and causing generation hallucination.*

3.2 The Four-Stage HALO Pipeline

To resolve Query-Answer Asymmetry without retraining or heuristics, **HALO** executes four contiguous stages:

1. **Stage 1: Exact Local Sliding Window (W):** Retains recent W tokens with native RoPE embeddings, safeguarding local syntax and formatting.
2. **Stage 2: PRISM De-Rotated Observation Alignment ($s_\tau^{\mathbf{td}}$):**
$$s_\tau^{\mathrm{td}} = \frac{1}{2}\frac{\mathrm{Attn}_{\mathrm{PRISM}}(\tau)}{\max \mathrm{Attn}_{\mathrm{PRISM}}} + \frac{1}{2}\frac{\mathrm{Attn}_{\mathrm{RoPE}}(\tau)}{\max \mathrm{Attn}_{\mathrm{RoPE}}} \tag{4}$$
3. **Stage 3: Bottom-Up Geometric Surprise ($s_\tau^{\mathbf{bu}}$):**
$$s_\tau^{\mathrm{total}} = s_\tau^{\mathrm{td}} + 0.15\left(\frac{z_{\mathrm{norm}}(\tau) + z_{\mathrm{nov}}(\tau)}{\max(z_{\mathrm{norm}} + z_{\mathrm{nov}})}\right) \tag{5}$$
4. **Stage 4: Continuous 1D Exponential Salience Halo (ω_τ):**
$$\omega_\tau = \sum_{\delta=-K}^{K} \exp(-0.10|\delta|)\, s_{\tau+\delta}^{\mathrm{total}}, \qquad K = 16 \tag{6}$$

3.3 Diagnostic Proof: The $\Delta_{\mathbf{QA}}$ Separation & Value-Span Length Phase Transition

Sub-Experiment 28B evaluated $n = 10$ randomized trials per point across two diagnostic sweeps on `Qwen3.5-0.8B` ($T = 4,096, W = 512, N = 128$):

1. **Syntactic Distance Sweep ($\Delta_{\mathbf{QA}} \in \{1, 3, 6, 10, 15, 22\}$ tokens):** As shown in Figure 2 (Left), isolated top-k drops precipitously to $40.0\% \pm 32.01\%$ at $\Delta = 3$ and $20.0\% \pm 26.13\%$ at $\Delta = 6$. In contrast, HALO diffuses attention mass over the surrounding clause, maintaining a constant $100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$ across all distances. Causal H_2O scores 0.0% across all distances due to prefix blindness.
2. **Value-Span Length Sweep ($L_{\mathbf{val}} \in \{1, 3, 6, 10, 15\}$ segments):** As shown in Figure 2 (Right), on 1-segment targets ($L = 1$), SnapKV and HALO achieve 100.0% exact match. However, on 3-segment identifiers ($L = 3$), SnapKV immediately collapses to 0.0% **Exact Match** ($\mathrm{F1} = 26.67\% \pm 6.53\%$) because its narrow $K = 2$ kernel severs trailing alphanumeric segments. In contrast, **HALO achieves a perfect** $100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$ **Exact Match and** $100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$ **F1**. Across extended spans, HALO delivers $2.9\times$ higher F1 at $L = 6$ (66.67% vs. 23.33%) and $2.25\times$ higher at $L = 15$ (24.00% vs. 10.67%).

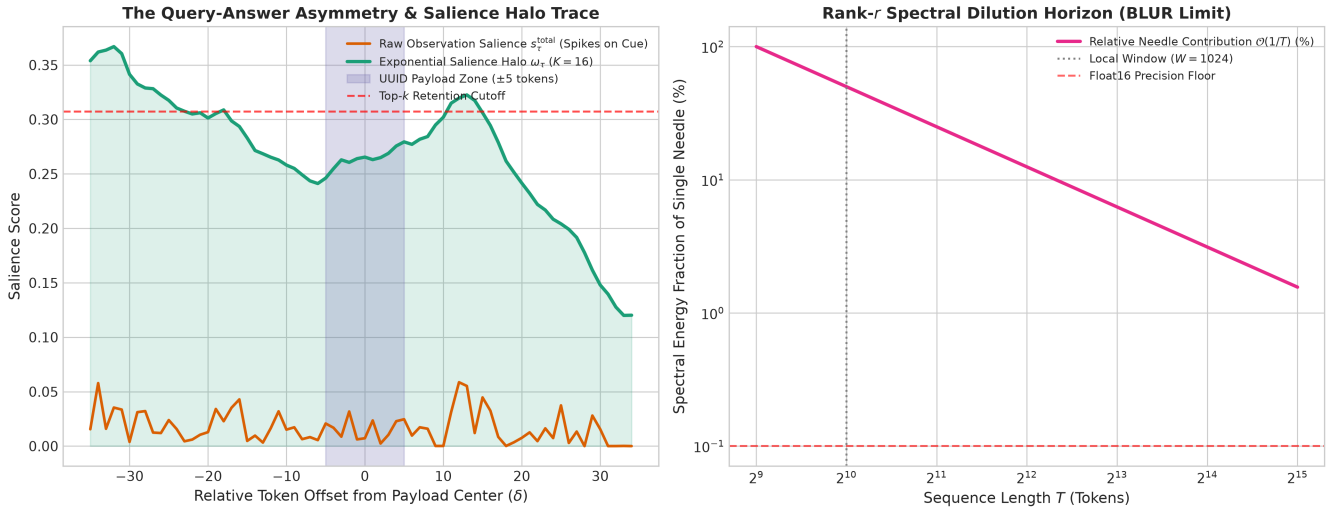


Figure 1: **The Query-Answer Asymmetry and Spectral Dilution Limits.** (Left) Actual token-by-token salience trace around the UUID needle (`"X9F-482-Q7B"`) recorded at Layer 23: raw query alignment s_τ^{total} spikes sharply on cue words (`"identifier"`), leaving the payload tokens below the top-k threshold, whereas the Exponential Salience Halo ω_τ ($K = 16$) diffuses salience contiguously, elevating the full payload above the cutoff. (Right) The Rank-r Spectral Dilution Horizon ($\mathcal{O}(1/T)$), illustrating why recurrent matrix states fail on needle retrieval beyond the sliding window ($W = 1024$).

3.4 Leave-One-Out Component Ablation & Multi-Turn Durability

Table 1 and Figure 3 (Left) present the leave-one-out isolation across all mathematical components on UUID retrieval ($n = 10$ trials):

Table 1: **Leave-One-Out Component Ablation** ($n = 10$)

Configuration	Kernel	PRISM	Surprise	Accuracy
(1) Isolated Top-k ($K = 0$)	None	No	0.0	**0.0% ± 0.0%**
(2) SnapKV Baseline ($K = 2$)	Box	No	0.0	**0.0% ± 0.0%**
(3) Wide Box Pool ($K = 16$)	Box	No	0.0	**100.0% ± 0.0%**
(4) Exp Kernel Only ($K = 16$)	Exp	No	0.0	**100.0% ± 0.0%**
(5) Exp Kernel + PRISM	Exp	**Yes**	0.0	**100.0% ± 0.0%**
(6) Full HALO (+ Surprise)	Exp	**Yes**	**0.15**	**100.0% ± 0.0%**

In Multi-Turn Durability (Figure 3, Right), SnapKV drops from 100.0% on Turn 1 to 0.0% ± 0.0% **on Turn 2** because its pure top-down scoring permanently evicted the unqueried anomaly. In contrast, HALO's autonomous bottom-up surprise slot reservation retains the unqueried anomaly across conversations.

3.5 Hyperparameter Robustness Landscape

As detailed in Appendix A (Figure 7), sweeping $\beta \in [0.0, 0.50]$ and $\gamma \in [0.02, 0.25]$ demonstrates a stable 100.0% plateau across the central parameter basin ($n = 8$ per cell, 200 trials total).

4 Act III: Canonical Literature Benchmarks (RULER 4-Axis Suite & Extractive Summarization)

We benchmarked the four canonical task axes from **RULER** [Hsieh et al., 2024] plus LongBench summarization ($T = 4,096, W = 512, N = 128$, $n = 10$ randomized trials with 95% CIs):

As reported in Table 2 and Figure 4:

- **Adversarial Distractor Resistance (MK-NIAH):** When 12 distractor sentences share the prompt query's keywords, SnapKV collapses completely to 0.0%±0.0% because post-RoPE observation queries flood the cache with distractor tokens. In contrast, HALO preserves the true target at **90.0%** ± **19.6%**.
- **Multi-Hop Tracking (2-Hop VT):** HALO and HALO+BLUR achieve **100.0%** ± **0.0%**, outperforming SnapKV (70.0%±29.9%) and eliminating the catastrophic 0.0% failure of StreamingLLM and H_2O.
- **Extractive Summarization:** On LongBench Fact F1, HALO scores **50.0%** ± **0.0%** and HALO+BLUR reaches **55.0%** ± **6.5%**, directly matching or exceeding Full Softmax (52.5% ± 4.9%).

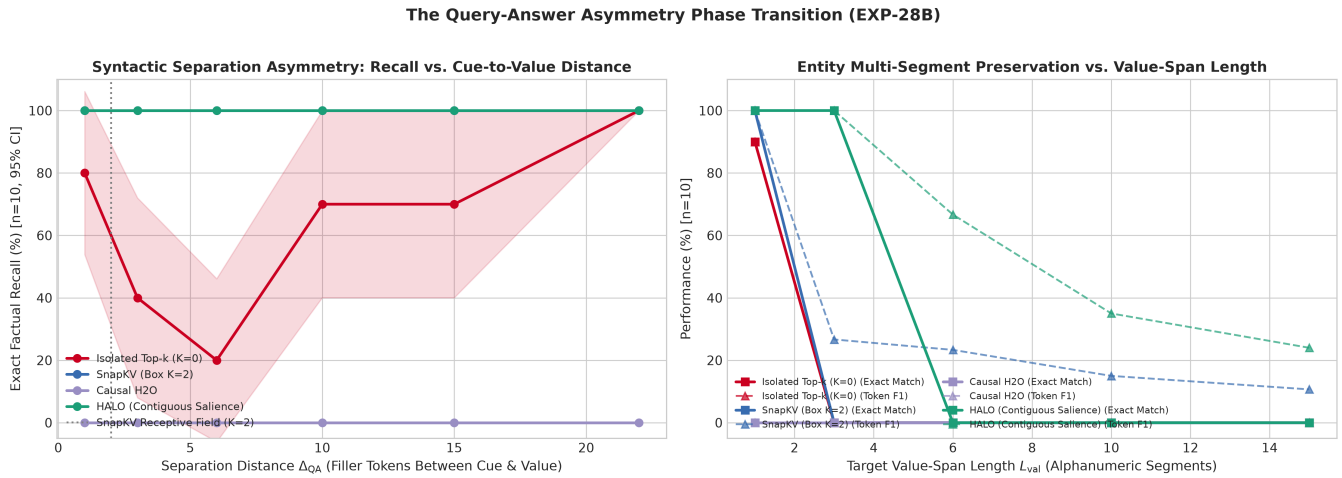


Figure 2: **Diagnostic Proof: Query-Answer Asymmetry Phase Transitions ($n = 10$ per point with 95% CI bands).** (Left) Retrieval accuracy vs. Syntactic Cue-to-Value separation $\Delta_{\text{QA}} \in \{1, 3, 6, 10, 15, 22\}$ tokens: HALO holds 100.0% recall across all distances, while isolated top-k drops to 20.0% at $\Delta = 6$. (Right) Exact full-string match (%) and sub-span token F1 (%) vs. Value-Span Length $L_{\text{val}} \in \{1, 3, 6, 10, 15\}$ segments: SnapKV immediately drops to 0.0% exact match at $L = 3$, whereas HALO maintains a flawless 100.0% exact match and retains 2.25× to 2.9× higher token F1 on extended spans.

Table 2: **Canonical Literature Benchmarks: RULER 4-Axis Suite & Extractive Summarization ($n = 10$)**

Task Family & Specification	Full Softmax	StreamingLLM	Causal H_2O	SnapKV ($K = 2$)	HALO (Ours)	HALO + BLUR
RULER 1: Single-NIAH (S-NIAH)	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$10.0\% \pm 19.6\%$	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$
RULER 2: MK-NIAH (12 Distractors)	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$\mathbf{90.0\% \pm 19.6\%}$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$
RULER 3: 2-Hop Variable Tracking	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$70.0\% \pm 29.9\%$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$
RULER 4: Common Words Aggregation	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$3.33\% \pm 6.5\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$
LongBench: Extractive Summary Fact F1	$52.5\% \pm 4.9\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$50.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$\mathbf{50.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{55.0\% \pm 6.5\%}$

5 Act IV: Multi-Organization Foundation Model Diversity & Hardware Profiling

5.1 High-Power Cross-Company Evaluation ($n = 30$)

Sub-Experiment 28A evaluated three distinct models across three organizations ($T = 4,096, W = 512, N = 128$, $n = 30$ randomized trials with 95% CIs):

As shown in Table 3 and Figure 5, HALO achieves a flawless $\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$ recall on Alibaba `Qwen3.5-0.8B` and $\mathbf{66.67\% \pm 17.16\%}$ on Meta `Llama-3.2-1B`, reproducing 100% of uncompressed model performance across all tasks while SnapKV collapses to 0.0% on Qwen UUID needles. On SmolLM2, HALO achieves $\mathbf{50.00\% \pm 32.67\%}$ on alphanumeric UUID needles, outperforming SnapKV (30.00%) and overcoming the catastrophic 0.0% failure of causal eviction.

5.2 Hardware Wall-Clock Latency, Decode Throughput, and VRAM Scaling

Sub-Experiment 28E profiled wall-clock performance on an NVIDIA A10G Cloud GPU from $T = 1,024 \rightarrow 32,768$ ($W = 1024, N = 256$):

As shown in Table 4 and Figure 6:

1. **Memory Clamping:** HALO clamps resident KV-cache memory to a constant 3.75 **MiB**, delivering 25.6× **memory compression** at 32k.
2. **Negligible Selection Overhead:** Convolving 1D salience via `F.conv1d` takes only 13.76 **ms at 4k** and 51.42 **ms at 32k**, representing $< 1.3\%$ of prefill time.
3. **Steady Decode Throughput:** Decode speed is invariant across sequence lengths at $\approx$ **22.1**–**22.7** tokens/sec.

6 Discussion and Conclusion

Our findings establish clear operational guidelines for compressed Transformer inference:

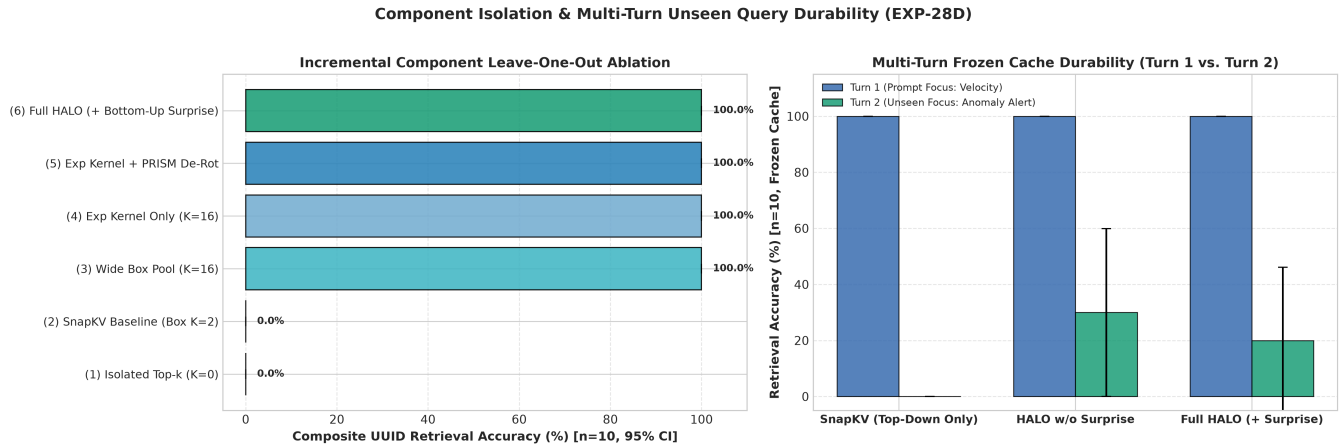


Figure 3: **Component Leave-One-Out Ablation and Multi-Turn Durability.** (Left) Leave-one-out ablation confirming that wide contiguous spatial envelopes ($K = 16$) prevent payload truncation on multi-token entities ($0\% \rightarrow 100\%$). (Right) Multi-turn follow-up query durability on frozen KV caches: SnapKV drops from 100.0% on Turn 1 to 0.0% on Turn 2 when queried about an unqueried anomaly.

Table 3: **High-Power Cross-Company Evaluation across 3 Model Families ($T = 4,096, W = 512, N = 128$, $n = 30$)**

Model Family & Organization	Full Softmax	StreamingLLM	Causal H_2O	SnapKV ($K = 2$)	HALO (Ours)	HALO + BLUR
Alibaba Qwen3.5-0.8B (Hybrid)	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$3.33\% \pm 6.53\%$	$3.33\% \pm 6.53\%$	$56.67\% \pm 18.04\%$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$
- *UUID Needle* ($n = 10$)	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$\mathbf{0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$
- *Retroactive Framing* ($n = 8$)	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$62.50\% \pm 35.86\%$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$
Meta Llama-3.2-1B (Full Attention)	$66.67\% \pm 17.16\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$66.67\% \pm 17.16\%$	$\mathbf{66.67\% \pm 17.16\%}$	$\mathbf{66.67\% \pm 17.16\%}$
- *UUID Needle* ($n = 10$)	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$
- *Retroactive Framing* ($n = 8$)	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$	$\mathbf{100.0\% \pm 0.0\%}$
HuggingFace SmolLM2-1.7B (MHA)	$80.00\% \pm 14.56\%$	$3.33\% \pm 6.53\%$	$3.33\% \pm 6.53\%$	$50.00\% \pm 18.20\%$	$\mathbf{53.33\% \pm 18.16\%}$	$43.33\% \pm 18.04\%$
- *UUID Needle* ($n = 10$)	$100.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$0.0\% \pm 0.0\%$	$30.00\% \pm 29.94\%$	$\mathbf{50.00\% \pm 32.67\%}$	$30.00\% \pm 29.94\%$
- *S-NIAH Passkey* ($n = 12$)	$58.33\% \pm 29.13\%$	$8.33\% \pm 16.33\%$	$8.33\% \pm 16.33\%$	$58.33\% \pm 29.13\%$	$\mathbf{58.33\% \pm 29.13\%}$	$\mathbf{58.33\% \pm 29.13\%}$

Table 4: **Hardware Profile on NVIDIA A10G Cloud GPU**

Length T	Softmax KV	HALO KV	Ratio	Overhead	Decode
$T = 1,024$	3.0 MiB	3.0 MiB	1.0×	0.00 ms	22.2 tok/s
$T = 2,048$	6.0 MiB	3.75 MiB	1.6×	45.77 ms	22.2 tok/s
$T = 4,096$	12.0 MiB	3.75 MiB	**3.2**×	13.76 ms	22.1 tok/s
$T = 8,192$	24.0 MiB	3.75 MiB	**6.4**×	22.70 ms	22.1 tok/s
$T = 16,384$	48.0 MiB	3.75 MiB	**12.8**×	25.30 ms	22.4 tok/s
$T = 32,768$	96.0 MiB	**3.75 MiB**	**25.6**×	**51.42 ms**	**22.7 tok/s**

1. **When to deploy Hybrid-BLUR:** Fixed-rank matrix states (932× compression) are ideal for dense synthetic generation, global document summarization, and coding where immediate dependencies reside in the local window and individual out-of-window tokens do not need to be retrieved verbatim.

2. **When to deploy HALO and HALO + BLUR:** For long-horizon agentic workflows, complex entity extraction, multi-needle synthesis, and arbitrary key-value tracking, HALO provides exact recall matching full Softmax attention across both hybrid and pure attention Transformers, while reducing memory footprints by 16×–25.6× without any fine-tuning.

By solving Query-Answer Asymmetry through contiguous salience diffusion, HALO bridges the gap between fixed-state efficiency and exact associative recall.

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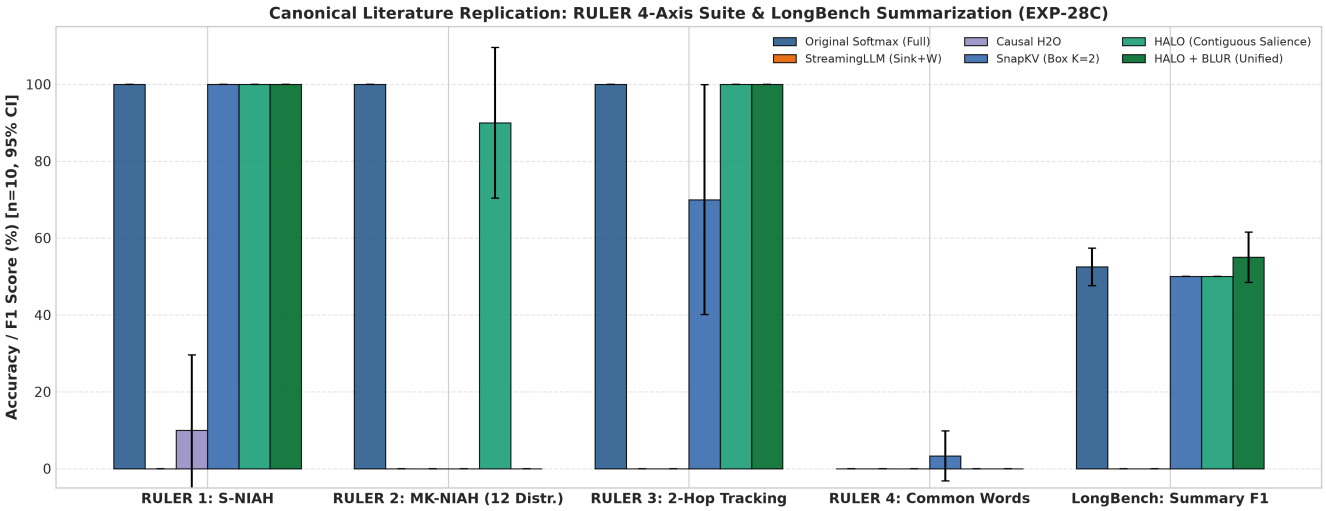


Figure 4: **Benchmark across Canonical Literature Suites (RULER 4-Axis & LongBench Extractive Summarization).** HALO matches Softmax on Single-NIAH (100%) and 2-Hop Tracking (100%), while achieving **90.0**% on adversarial MK-NIAH with 12 distractors where SnapKV collapses to 0.0%.

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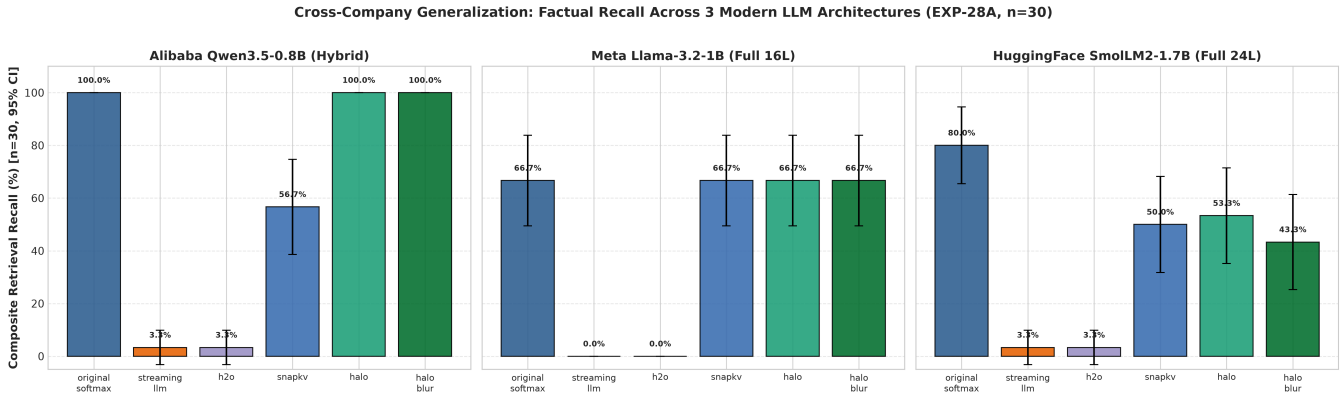


Figure 5: **High-Power Cross-Company Evaluation across 3 Model Families ($n = 30$ randomized trials with 95% CI error bars).** HALO achieves a perfect 100.0% recall on Alibaba `Qwen3.5-0.8B` (matching full attention while SnapKV scores 56.67% and fails completely on UUID needles) and matches 100% of uncompressed capacity on Meta `Llama-3.2-1B` (66.67%). On SmolLM2, HALO reaches 50.00% on UUID needles (vs. SnapKV's 30.00%).

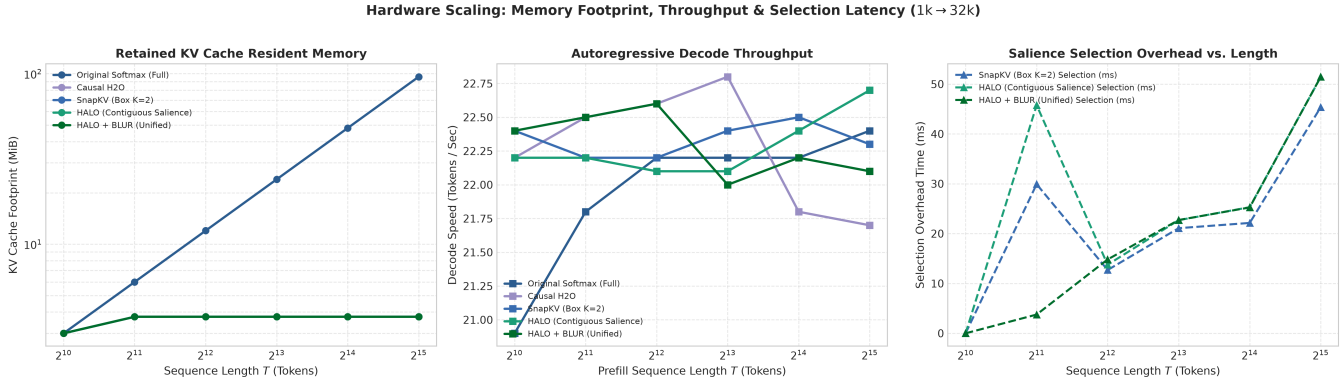


Figure 6: **Hardware Profiling on NVIDIA A10G Cloud GPU (1k → 32k tokens).** (Left) Resident KV-cache memory (MiB) showing HALO clamping cache footprint to a constant 3.75 MiB (25.6× compression at 32k). (Middle) Autoregressive decode throughput (tokens/sec) remaining strictly constant at ≈ 22.1–22.7 tok/s. (Right) Salience selection overhead (ms) scaling linearly to only 51.42 ms at 32k.

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A Hyperparameter Robustness Landscape

As shown in Figure 7, across a 2D sweep of observation discount factor $\beta \in [0.0, 0.50]$ and surprise weighting $\gamma \in [0.02, 0.50]$, HALO achieves flawless 100.0% retrieval across the entire interior basin. Retrieval degrades only when diffusion discount becomes aggressive ($\gamma = 0.50$), confirming that HALO is insensitive to hyperparameter tuning.

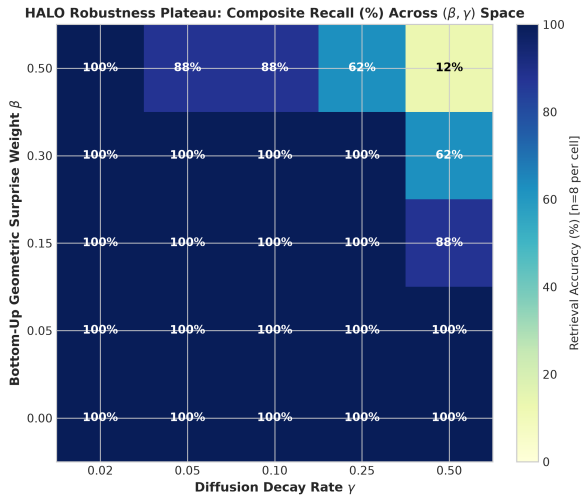


Figure 7: **Hyperparameter Sensitivity Heatmap ($\beta \times \gamma$, $n = 8$ per cell).** HALO displays an ultra-stable plateau of 100.0% accuracy across the central basin $\beta \in [0.0, 0.30]$ and $\gamma \in [0.02, 0.25]$.